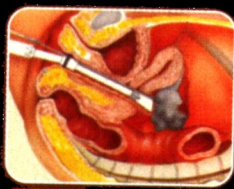
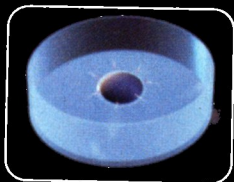


THE STORK CLUB

The number of IVF cycles has gone up from 7,273 in 2001 to 19,005 in 2005, with most women being in the 30-35 age group



IVF Rs 1 LAKH
STEP 1 Eggs are retrieved from the ovaries after super ovulation.



STEP 2 Eggs are fertilised with the sperm in a petri dish, leading to the formation of embryos.



STEP 3 In some cases embryo wall is broken with a diode laser before transfer, to help it to hatch and escape.



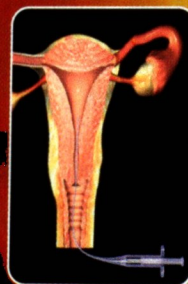
STEP 4 Multiple embryos are transferred into the uterus to ensure conception.

ICSI Rs 1.2 LAKH
THE FIRST TWO STEPS ARE SIMILAR TO IVF.

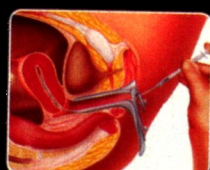
STEP 3 Sperm is injected into the egg directly.



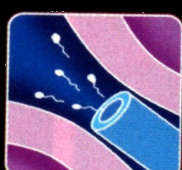
STEP 4 Embryos are transferred into the uterus.



IUI Rs 10,000
STEP 1 Sperm are first washed and then placed in a sterile medium.



STEP 2 Sperm are taken in a small volume and directly injected into the uterus.



STEP 3 Sperm are placed high in the uterus to enhance chances of fertilisation.

ALL THREE PROCEDURES ASSIST CONCEPTION, BUT DO NOT GUARANTEE IT IN THE FIRST ATTEMPT.

RISKS

1) Hyper stimulation of ovaries is a condition of enlargement of ovaries due to the hormone injections for producing multiple eggs.

2) In the egg retrieval procedure, the internal organs such as bowels, bladder or blood vessels may get injured; though this is extremely rare.

3) Multiple embryo implants may give rise to multiple pregnancies and ensuing complications such as premature delivery or miscarriage.

4) There is a possibility of low birth weight and mental disability only if the pregnancy is multiple, but the IVF treatment does not increase the risk by itself.

Jersey, USA and thinking about getting the tests done there, which was next to insanity due to high medical costs," says Shah. She began her investigation after getting back to India six years ago. "I went through a number of tests and the doctors told me that my infertility was due to unexplained reasons," says Shah, whose IUI treatment failed six times. After an unending cycle of blood tests Parikh found that Shah's infertility was due to high number of antibodies in ovaries. And Shah did not want to waste more time waiting.

Graphic designer Ritika Lambha, 35, has been married for 11 years and gave birth five months back after a three-year wait. Lambha, who suffered from polycystic ovaries syndrome,

thought about starting a family at 32 and was stunned when her doctor gave her a meagre 20 per cent chance of conception. She took a chance with Parikh and became pregnant in her second IVF attempt. But with more than three embryos placed in the womb, she ended up with four conceptions, leading to another ordeal—the reduction treatment, in which extra embryos are removed. Her twins came after she acquired a vaginal cyst, was hospitalised six times prior to delivery and had gestational diabetes, not to talk of being bedridden till the day of delivery.

"A lot of psychological counselling is necessary to prepare a patient for the outcome," says Indira Hinduja, consultant gynaecologist and obstetrician,

KEM Hospital, Mumbai, who has made 2,500 babies in the past five years and whose clinic has 50-60 women undergoing IVF treatment every month. A majority of the women who opt for the treatment fall in the age group of 30 to 35. Kamini Rao, who established the Bangalore Assisted Conception Centre in 1989, says, the number of women in their 30s seeking assisted conception is increasing. Often though, says gynaecologist Puneet Bedi, such treatments are a crutch, adding, "Seventy per cent of infertile people just don't have sex often enough. Those who start their families late, already limit them." But for women who are racing against time and nature, it is better to be late and limited than never.